

Ryan R. Rajpal

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Education

Rutgers University - School of Arts and Sciences

New Brunswick, NJ

B.A. Summa Cum Laude in Political Science, Philosophy

May 2025

- **Thesis:** “Exploring Political Content on Social Media: What Does Playful Activism Really Do?” (Highest Honors)

Research Interests

Topics: Public Opinion; Public Behavior; Media Studies; Political Parties; Social Dynamics; Political Socialization; Cognition; Emotions **Methods:** Survey Experiments; Computational Text Analysis; Ethnography

Research Experience

PPL Institute

Independent Researcher

Remote

May 2025 - Present

Department of Political Science, Rutgers University

Research Assistant

New Brunswick, NJ

Jan 2024 - May 2026

Aresty Research Center, Rutgers University

Research Assistant

New Brunswick, NJ

Oct 2024 - Apr 2025

Network Contagion Research Institute

Research Assistant

Princeton, NJ

May 2024 - Dec 2024

Social Perception Lab, Rutgers University

Research Assistant

New Brunswick, NJ

May 2023 - May 2024

Manuscripts in Progress

Rajpal, R. R. (In Progress). “The Queer Republican: Gay Men, Conservative Masculinity, and Regional Identity Formation.”

Funk, A., Krumholz, K., **Rajpal, R.**, & McCabe, K. (In Progress). “Is Talking Politics Always Risky Business? Experimental Interventions to Create Positive Political Discussion in Non-Political Spaces.”

Research Reports

Grayon, A. R., Co, L., Iino, P., **Rajpal, R. R.** (2026). When the Temperature Rises: How Local Heat Exposure Relates to Public Opinions on Reproductive Rights in the United States. *PPL Institute*.

<https://www.pplinstitute.org/When-the-Temperature-Rises-How-Local-Heat-Exposure-Relates-to-Public-Opinions-on-Reproductive-Rights-in-the-United-States.html>

Rajpal, R. R., Grayon, A. R., & Iino, P. (2025). Who Are You Talking To? The Discernment of AI and Human Content on Social Media. *PPL Institute*.

<https://www.pplinstitute.org/Who-Are-You-Talking-To-The-Discernment-of-AI-and-Human-Content-on-Social-Media.html>

Goldenberg, A., McCann-Phillips, C., Jagdeep, A., Lazarus, S., Zeher, M., Fedida, O., Fihrer, G., Finkelstein, J., Gamil, F., Finkelstein, D., Yanovsky, S., **Rajpal, R.**, & Jussim, L. (2024). The Botification of The American Mind. *Network Contagion Research Institute*. <https://networkcontagion.us/reports/the-botification-of-the-american-mind/>

Jussim, L., Yanovsky, S., Finkelstein, D., Finkelstein, J., Donohue, J., Goldenberg, A., Patel, S., Selby, E., Glover, T., Vasko, C., Jagdeep, A., Abdallah, L., Harley, S., Ibrahim, C., Kalisch-Cellai, C., Karra, P., Mehta, A., & **Rajpal, R.** (2024). One Click Away: A Study on the Prevalence and Accessibility of Non-Suicidal Self Injury, Suicide, and Eating Disorder Content in Search Engines. *Network Contagion Research Institute*.

<https://www.ofcom.org.uk/siteassets/resources/documents/research-and-data/online-research/one-click-away/one-click-away-a-study-on-the-prevalence-of-non-suicidal-self-injury-suicide-and-eating-disorder-content-accessible-by-search-engines?v=330836>

Conferences and Presentations

National Conferences

Rajpal, R.R. (2025, April). Exploring Political Content on Social Media: What Does Playful Activism Really Do? [Poster Presentation]. Midwest Political Science Association, Chicago, Illinois.

Funk, A., **Rajpal, R.R.** (2024, September). Is Talking Politics Always Risky Business? Experimental Interventions to Create Positive Political Discussion in Non-Political Spaces [Poster Presentation]. American Political Science Association Political Psychology Pre-Conference, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania.

Other Presentations

Rajpal, R.R. (2025, April). Exploring Political Content on Social Media: What Does Playful Activism Really Do? [Poster presentation]. Political Science Thesis Symposium, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, New Jersey.

Connelly, R., **Rajpal, R. R.** (2025, April). State Demographics and Representation: What Inspires Women of Color to Run? [Poster presentation]. Aresty Undergraduate Research Symposium, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, New Jersey.

Rajpal, R.R. (2024, April). Understanding the Techno-political Landscape: The Evolution of Digital Activism [Poster presentation]. Lloyd C. Gardner Fellowship Research Symposium, Rutgers University, New Brunswick, New Jersey.

Awards and Fellowships

Henry Rutgers Scholar – Outstanding Research Thesis, Rutgers University	2025
Paul Robeson Scholar, Rutgers University	2025
Neil McDonald Prize – Best Paper in Political Science, Rutgers University	2025
Jacob Cooper Prize in Logic – Highest Competitive Examination in Logic, Rutgers University	2025
<i>Pi Sigma Alpha - Beta Omicron</i> Honor Society, Political Science Honor Society	2024
<i>Phi Sigma Tau - Theta</i> Honor Society, Philosophy Honor Society	2023
Lloyd C. Gardner Fellowship, Rutgers University	2023-2024
School of Arts and Sciences Excellence Award, Rutgers University	2022-2025

Teaching Experience

Kelly Education	South Plainfield, NJ
Substitute Teacher	Jan 2025 - June 2025
Department of Psychology, Rutgers University	New Brunswick, NJ
Learning Assistant, General Psychology 101	Sep 2023 - Dec 2024

Professional Experience

Middlesex County Prosecutor’s Office	New Brunswick, NJ
Trial and Juvenile Crime Intern	Sep 2023 - Apr 2024

Leadership

<i>Phi Sigma Tau - Theta</i> Honor Society
President (Apr 2024 - Apr 2025); Social Media Officer (Apr 2023 - Apr 2024)
The Institute of Domestic and International Affairs
Vice President (Apr 2024 - Apr 2025); Committee Director/Assistant Director (Jan 2023 – Feb 2025); Director of Digital Content (Apr 2023 - Apr 2024)

Skills

Technical: R, STATA, Excel, HTML/CSS, JavaScript (beginner)

Tools: GitHub, Visual Studio Code, Canva, Adobe Suite, Microsoft/Google Office